

Phii's Guide to Gaining Weight

I've successfully and purposefully gained around 19kg of weight (mostly fat tissue and possibly some supporting muscle mass) over the past weeks (around 1.5kg per week), and since I've been asked by a few people how I achieved this, I have decided to write down my observations, the things I read online, and a small sprinkle of pet theories into a guide.

This guide is based on personal experience (your mileage may vary) and mostly written for those interested in quick weight gain, which, if you are very worried about e.g. stretch marks or the like, might not be for you. It's also written from the perspective of a girly who has been underweight-ish for pretty much all of her life and rarely (if ever) gained any weight before, and might therefore be overkill if your metabolism is different from that.

Also content warning for mention of food items of varying vegan-ness and vegetarianning-ness (though all of the ones I personally ate were vegetarian).

Stating the obvious (information that is only needed if you are new to the concept of human bodies)

The key to gaining weight is not to eat more, but to eat more *per time*. This is easily demonstrated by the fact that saving someones life, thus extending it by multiple days at least, will increase the amount of food they eat in total (because they will get to eat food that, had they died, they would have never gotten to eat, on account of being dead), but won't automatically cause them to gain weight.

Furthermore, the amount you eat does not directly dictate your weight, but rather dictate the (rate of) change of your weight (whether you gain or loose weight and if so, how much). Mathematically speaking, you're looking to temporarily change your diet in a way that positively alters the derivate function of your weight, and when you've gained the amount you want, you want to alter it in a way that causes the derivate function to be 0.

The Basics

The key to gaining weight is not to eat more food per day, but to eat more *calories* per day. Every food item contains a certain amount of calories per mass, and these calories are what gives your body energy to perform tasks, both mental, physical, and internal (invisible to you). Calories are basically the stuff that ends up powering the mitochondrias, the „powerhouses of the cell“ that you most likely learned about in biology class at some point.

Calories are usually measured in kcal (kilo-calories), with one kilo-calory equalling 1000 calories; however, if something says that an item of food contains so-and-so-many calories, they usually actually mean kilo-calories, despite one kilo-calory technically referring to 1000 calories.

Your body needs a certain amount of calories per day to power itself, and this amount varies day to day depending on how much mental and physical activity you do (and stuff like your body's immune system or temperature regulation system being very busy). If you eat more calories than needed, your body will (caveats apply; elaborated on later down the line) turn those into fat tissue. If you eat less, your body will create calories by „burning“ fat tissue. This means that, in order to gain weight, you need to eat at a calory-surplus, as in, you need to eat more than your body requires.

Some Numbers

Here are some generalized numbers:

- You can find online calculators and formulas to calculate your caloric needs based on your weight and how much exercise you get; these calculations are, of course, simplified, because they don't account e.g. for how much of your weight is fat and how much is muscles, and don't account for mental exercise very well.
However, the amount is probably somewhere in the 1500-2000 kcal range (or at least it was for me, at 65-75 kilos).
- It is said that around 3500 kcal equals one pound of fat tissue, which means that 7777 (what a clunky number) equals around 1 kg of fat tissue. „Equals“, in this context, means that eating 7777 kcal more than what you need (accumulated over time) leads to gaining one kilogram of weight, and eating 7777 kcal less than what you need leads to losing 1 kg of weight.
As mentioned earlier, there are some caveats to the calory-surplus-side of this; we will dig into these in the next section.

These numbers are for the average person.

The amount you need to eat might be higher if you tend to have digestion issues (i.e. some of the food you eat goes through you under-digested), or lower if your digestion is ultra efficient.

Some Caveats

Eating a lot of calories at once (like in a single day, for example) will not lead to weight gain if your digestion isn't used to getting this amount of caloric surplus, and it will likely flush out most of the excess (don't take me up on my word for this if you're trying to *lose* weight, because my source for this is fucking Reddit).

That means that you probably want to eat a roughly even amount of caloric surplus from day to day, rather than e.g. eating a bunch of food each Friday and „normal“ amounts on other days.

Furthermore –and this is a pet theory– there might be a certain amount of caloric excess you need to eat per day (varying per person) in order for your body to start storing the excess at all.

For example, spreading the 7777 kcal you need to eat in excess to gain 1 kg over the course of 3 months might not work, I suspect, although I cannot be sure of that.

There is probably also a limit to how fast your body can put on weight (idk if much more is possible than the 1.5kg a week I got), plus you might want to gain slower if you're concerned about stretch marks or the like.

How to eat more calories

> Bigger portion sizes

Your first idea as to an approach to eat more calories might be to eat more per meal.

This does, of course, work, if executed successfully, but might also fail because you are already eating to your full capacity. Managing your motivation is key to executing long-term projects like gaining weight, and eating in a way that makes you uncomfortable (e.g. because you force yourself to eat more than what your stomach feels it can handle) can damage that motivation, meaning that I would be cautious with this strategy.

That being said, if you intend to learn to eat bigger portion sizes (which I did, by the way, over time), here are some things to consider:

- Increase gradually, if possible.
- You can always eat your first portion, then watch an episode of a series or smth, and then eat your second portion, if it becomes too much; failure to eat it all up at once doesn't mean you need to throw food away. Take pauses if you feel very full!!
- You can even leave over some part of your food to eat as an additional meal on the next day, if you can fit another meal into a day (some tips later down the line might clash with that).
- When you feel sated mostly depends on the calories in your food (I think), but when you feel full depends on your stomach. Your stomach feeling full, however, doesn't necessarily mean that it is really at its limit, but can also just mean that it is at the limit of what it is used to. Eating to that limit (or carefully slightly over it) might over time extend how much you can eat before your stomach sends the "stop"-signal.

> More meals

Instead of (or in addition to) eating more per meal, you can also increase how many meals you eat per day (I would recommend that).

This can be tricky because there is money and/or time and energy involved with making additional meals, so here are some suggestions, a subset of whom you might choose to go for:

- You can turn your breakfast into a bigger (in terms of calories) breakfast. This is, of course, harder to prepare than e.g. cereal, but if you make yourself the same breakfast each day, you might get into a rhythm where it fits exactly into the allocated time frame between waking up and going to work/uni/whatever.
- If you're a university student, for example, you might be able to get an affordable lunch at uni each day that you don't even have to prepare for yourself. They might even have caloric information on their website for each meal!
- If you do not go to an uni or workplace with an affordable food option included, and you can eat lunch at home, you could cook bigger batches for dinner each day and eat half of it for lunch the next day. Cooking a full pack of spaghetti (instead of ½) and double the amount of sauce is much less than double the effort, for example. Of course, this is more difficult if you are living and eating with someone else, because then you'll cook more per meal anyways, which might be harder to scale up due to limited pot- and pan sizes (which is why I don't go for this strategy).

> More calorie-dense food

You also want to try to get your calories from calorie-dense food (instead of not-very-calorie-dense food), since this way you need to fill up your stomach less than if you got all of your calories from e.g. soups and salads.

It is also worth noting here that baked good with lots of air inside ("fluffy" cakes) have the same calorie-per-weight ratio as their denser counterparts (e.g. brownies), but a worse calorie-per-volume ratio, which demonstrates that you prolly also want to make sure to eat foods that don't make you swallow a to of air.

You could also measure calorie-denseness in "calories per time to eat", since foods that you can eat a lot of before your body has an opportunity to realize you're already full (like the opposite of a soup) are more effective than foods that take a long time to eat.

There is information on the different food groups further down the line in this document, but for the purpose of this section, just remember this:

- DO eat more calorie-dense food
- DO NOT replace all of your food intake with whatever gives the most calories. The food you eat contains nutrients in addition to calories, which is stuff your body needs to replace

or fix (cell-level or molecular-level) parts that fail over time and need replacing, and cutting out food groups or replacing them with other more calory-dense food groups (to a too-big extent) is going to lead to deficiencies here. For example, you can eat more sugar and fatty food and cut back on salads, but you can't just cut out everything and live off nothing but mayonnaise. Your body needs all the food groups as well as variance within them even if your caloric needs are more than met.

> Snacking

Your stomach can only contain so much food at any given moment, which I guess kind of sucks. However, your body can contain so much food at EVERY given moment, which I guess kind of rules.

Any moment your stomach is empty in between meals is a moment in which it could be filled and using its digestion power to turn food into fat (simplified to be catchy). This can be remedied by snacking.

And since snacking is *in addition* to the meals you are already eating, you can just eat anything calory-dense for a snack without running into the issue described in the "DO NOT"-section above. Just make sure you pick snacks that aren't super filling to leave place for the actual meals you plan to eat.

I personally find brownies, bananas and hot chocolate to be quite pleasant, but more on that later.

How I eat to gain weight

I always eat the same hearty breakfast each morning (900 kcal due to the power of shepherd's cheese and lots of butter), then eat lunch at uni (600-1400 kcal), and a calory-dense dinner at home (1500-2000 kcal, spread over the course of the evening).

Something like potato salad (mayonnaise!), for example, tends to be very calory-dense.

On uni days, I ate an additional three bananas at uni each day.

On weekends when there is no uni lunch, I made brownies and ate around 4 (1000kcal, ¼ of a pan) a day.

I also drank large (400ml) hot chocolates (~400kcal) on the weekend, and sometimes under the week at home before dinner. Btw, you can make (a 200ml) hot chocolate with a pack of whipped cream instead of milk, which can have like 600kcal in itself, though idk how good that is on one's digestion (which is why I only did it thrice).

One week I ate 4 brownies a day (instead of three bananas) every day despite also having uni lunches almost every day, and it was quite effective.

Overall I tried to eat between 3000 and 4000 (usually within the upper range of that) each day.

I should also mention that I am vegetarian, so all of this was achieved without fish (which is high in fat).

Calory Density Comparisons & Food Suggestions

Fats are high in calories, which includes dairy products (look at the %-fat-information), stuff like mayonnaise, creams, oils, cheeses that aren't very aged, and stuff that contains oil like nuts. You probably don't want to eat mayonnaise or oils or really anything but milk and maybe good 50%-fat cheese in its pure form, since eating too much fat can cause your body to attempt to get rid of it via soft stool and sweating or increased lactating (hi!), but you should take this into account for sandwiches and (pasta) sauces. A cream-based (or blended-cashew-based) sauce is wayyyy higher in calories than e.g. tomato sauce. If you eat a lot sandwiches (which in some cultures is the

standard way of eating breakfast) you can put shepherd's cheese on it, which has a fat percentage of up to 55% and is as cheap as 7€ per kilo.

Sugars are also high in calories. You shouldn't eat too much of them because it increases the risk of developing diabetes, but temporarily eating lots of sugary snacks to gain weight should, I assume, be fine (I am not a doctor). Keep in mind that increased sugar intake increases how much fat gets placed in your belly area (vs other areas), so you might want to not use sugar as

Carbohydrates are less high in calories and more filling, but you need to eat a lot of them anyways and they're way better than vegetables and the like, so here comes my breakdown:

potatoes: 90 kcal/100gramm

cooked noodles: 159 kcal/100gramm

cooked rice: 127 kcal/100gramm

Potatoes might look very inefficient here, but they are (in their pure form) very dense, so that eating the same amount of kcal in the form of potatoes is much easier than in the form of noodles or rice, in my experience. Rice is very stuffing, so it scares lower than either noodles or potatoes to me. Fries (or chips, if you're British) tend to be very oily and are thus more calory-dense than pure potatoes, but they're also less dense to eat, so it kind of cancels out to me (your mileage may vary, though).

You can over time create and curate a list of all the foods in your food rotation with rough caloric estimates for each food. By "caloric estimate" I mean a calculation of calories that only takes into account the major elements of all the major calory-rich food groups contained in the food; this restriction makes the calculating act much easier. For example, you can ignore vegetables and spices and all sorts of small things in your calculations. Doing this will not only make it easier to calculate your caloric intake at the end of the day for tracking purposes, but also help you gain an intuitive understanding of which ingredients contain which amount of calories, ballpark-wise.

Weighting yourself effectively

Your weight varies throughout the day and from day to day due to the amount of liquid (pissing, sweating, drinking) and food (pissing, shitting) you have in you.

It is generally recommended to weight yourself after getting out of bed (as opposed to e.g. in the morning), since at this time you'll have slept, swet and potentially pissed for 8 hours without eating anything, meaning your weight is less influenced by variation in non-body-tissue matter than at other times of day.

Tracking Weight

Since your weight can vary in between different mornings for reasons unrelated to your body fat percentage, you shouldn't put too much value onto the number your scale give on an individual day. It is therefore imperative that you don't panic or get over-excited over the values of individual days, but rather over observable trends over time. I personally act on the assumption that, for my body, the lowest weight of the past four days can be assumed as a reasonable lower bound for my current weight, but you might find a different heuristic to feel true for you.

I use openScale (a FOSS android app) to track my weight and I would recommend to use one yourself; entering your weight and calories each day allows you to track progress and, if you try

different diets over different stretches of time, even allows you to make observations regarding your caloric needs, or your weight gain speed relative to how many excess calories you eat.

Getting back into a weight equilibrium

Once you have reached your desired weight (or look depending on what you base your goal condition on), you should go back to a weight equilibrium, as in, you want to go back to eating as many calories as your body need, lest you will overshoot your desired goal.

In order to make this easier, you should make sure to remember how you ate before you started your journey (e.g. “I ate cereal each morning, lunch at university, and dinner from my cooking rotation”), and take notes of changes you made (e.g. “I added three bananas and one big hot chocolate a day plus sugar to my cereal”) so you can re-roll them. These notes don’t have to be written or anything; just make sure you make active decisions so you can keep track of them, and don’t build habits that will be hard to break (e.g. don’t get your weight from addictive food like caffeinated chocolate or something, I guess).

In the beginning after going back you might feel more hungry than you used to before because your body got used to eating more; this should subside after a while if you let your body get used to your changed eating habits. Stay strong, soldier!

You can, if you’re not sure how much you need to eat to be in an equilibrium, hit the brakes as a test run for a week or two to figure it out so that you know how much to eat when it is actually time to hit the brakes.

Some Misconceptions

It is sometimes said that eating in the morning leads to less weight gain than in the evening, or vice versa, or that eating many small portions throughout the day leads to more weight gain than eating less big portions.

These claims are (if you ignore matters like „how do I best use my day to eat the most calories i can?“) scientifically wobbly and/or completely disproven by now.

You might also think that doing less exercise would help you gain weight, but this is the devil talking. Exercise is healthy for you, and the caloric difference between doing exercise and not doing it is neglectable compared to the difference that diet makes. Plus, if you think about it, muscles are like scaffolding for your fat tissue, visually speaking!

Body Size

If you are taller (or wider in frame, ignoring fat tissue) then any fat you gained will be distributed across a larger surface area, which means that gaining the same fat-layer-thickness or the same squishiness as a smaller person will take you a longer amount of time than them (then again you might also have a bigger stomach, but idk how these things scale with each other).

You should take this into account before comparing yourself negatively to other people, and might want to adjust your expectations accordingly.

Fat Tissue Placement

The places fat tissue goes to depends on your hormones (does your body run on estrogen and if so, how much, or does it run on testosterone).

You might have heard that starting HRT changes fat distribution patterns, but (to my understanding) this just means that any new fat (incl. fat that you re-gain after losing it) gets placed differently, which, if your weight is super stable, might be a very slow process.

Therefore, if you are looking towards starting HRT and towards gaining weight, I would recommend to first start HRT and then start gaining weight instead of vice versa.

As mentioned above excessive sugar consumption can also affect fat distribution patterns, which may or may not be relevant for you.

Avoid Eating Disorders

Try not to be too religious, dogmatic or obsessed over how much you eat or whether you hit your goal each day, try not to overeat too often (unless you're into it, I guess, maybe?), and so forth, because that could, I think, lead to an eating disorder or something.

Also remember that it is not a competition and to not compare yourself to other people too much! It's best to go for a body that you feel happy in instead of for one you feel will satisfy others.